

ANNA NAGAR

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The evolution of the bins.



LIFFY THOMAS

If waste segregation is still not part of the daily routine in your home, then get ready to fall in line. New rules are coming into effect on April 1, 2026. Under the revised Solid Waste Management (SWM) Rules 2026, notified recently by the Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, four-stream segregation of solid waste at source has been made mandatory. This means your household waste is required to be segregated into wet waste, dry waste, sanitary waste and special care waste; the later includes paint cans, bulbs, mercury thermometers and medicines.

The revised rules, which supersedes Solid Waste Management Rules, 2016, integrate the principles of circular economy and extended producer responsibility, with a specific focus on waste segregation and management.

Those working in this space say some major concerns in Chennai include gaps in availability collection vehicles and processing facilities. There is also a need to enforce rules strictly for all stakeholders.

All bulk waste generators are expected to process wet waste *in situ* or obtain an Extended Bulk Waste Generator Responsibility (EBWGR) certificate stating that on-site processing is not feasible.

Material recovery facilities (MRFs) are again in the spotlight. Under the revised rules, local bodies are responsible for the collection, segregation and transportation of solid waste in coordination with MRFs which may also act as deposition points for e-waste, special care waste, sanitary waste and other waste streams for further processing. MRFs have been formally recognised as facilities for sorting of solid waste, says the note.

Local bodies have been encouraged to generate carbon credits.

Local bodies

The new rules emphasises creation of a Centralised Online Portal to track all stages of solid waste management, including waste generation, transportation, processing and disposal, as well as biomineral and bioremediation of legacy waste dump sites. Registration and authorisation of waste processing facilities with local bodies and State Pollution Control Boards or Pollution Control Committees shall be carried out online through the portal developed by the CPCB.

The rules mandate audits of all waste processing facilities.

Take four

Here is what a cross-section of people from the city have to say about the revised Solid Waste Management (SWM) Rules 2026; the highlight is a four-bin system



VOICES

'Bulk generators must set an example'

Maintaining one more bin is going to be cumbersome for some residents, but it is just about getting used to the practice. We will be meeting to discuss how to bring about awareness about the new rules and how this new system can improve recycling efficiency and reducing landfill waste.

Currently, we follow the two bins, one bag method to collect waste. They were bought in bulk and given to residents for better compliance and uniformity. As in the past, we will have to educate all stakeholders about the rules. It is about consistent conversations and enforcement. Bulk waste generators like us have more reasons to follow rules and keep the city clean.

Our onsite composting has been had a hiatus and I hope the new rules will nudge us into finding new solutions to the challenges we faced in the past.

Sumitha Iyer, waste segregation team, The Central Park South and committee lead, FOMRRA Swacch Bharat

Bulk generators

Bulk waste generator includes entities with a floor area of **20,000 square metres** or more, or water consumption of **40,000 litres** per day or more, or solid waste generation of **100 kg** per day or more.

'We need to conduct awareness sessions'

The new SWM Rules 2026 lays emphasis on the responsibilities of all stakeholders in keeping a city clean by giving only segregated waste. It is possible to follow the four-bin system and we will start conducting awareness sessions. The battery-operated vehicles can accommodate eight bins, so it is just about having some systems in place. Managing sanitary waste is a challenge and if residents are responsible in the way they dispose of sanitary waste, then we will ensure it is taken to the incinerator.

Official, SWM, GCC

'Have stringent rules in place'

While I welcome four-way segregation of waste, I wonder how many of the current waste collection vehicles seen on Chennai roads have space to accommodate multiple bins. Local bodies must set aside dedicated days when different kinds of waste are collected and this must be communicated to residents so that segregation becomes a habit. When we worked in various neighbourhoods in the past, we had pressed separate vehicles into service for dry and wet waste. Stringent rules should be enforced to make contractors/waste management companies fall in line. I wished the revised rules had insisted that big housing projects create infrastructure for composting of waste before handing over the project to residents.

Mangalam Balasubramaniam, expert on solid waste management and founding president of Eco Chakra Abhiyan

'We will tweak our waste management rules'

Aashiana Apartment in Alwarpet is among the first gated communities in Chennai to start composting thanks to the small infrastructure created by the builder and the many programmes that we residents ran to get people to give only segregated waste. Even today our biodegradable waste is composted *in situ*. But we will have to tweak our waste management process as per the new SWM rules. Sanitary waste is currently included in dry waste. The new rules coming into force are only going to make it easier for us to enforce our segregation rules. Sadly non-compliance wittingly or otherwise happens at times and we have to keep reinforcing the rules.

Anita Hegde, Green Club volunteer, Aashiana Apartment

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PAVERS 'RETROFITTED'

The plants on Anna Salai outside Government Estate Metro Station are meant to be strapping big trees. Even after a recent redemptive exercise, they continue on a restrictive space, one certainly not meant for trees **P3**



CHENNAI RWA SHINES IN TN'S SOLAR RACE

Bollineni Hillside has bagged an award for the biggest solar rooftop installation in Tamil Nadu in the category for resident welfare associations **P4**

'Fix this electricity junction box in Kilpauk'

D.RADHAKRISHNAN

The image taken on February 13, 2026 shows the electricity junction box on Medavakkam Tank Road in Kilpauk, near TNSC Bank, Kellys Branch, standing precariously. Greater Chennai Corporation is currently carrying out stormwater drain work in the area. As a result of the ongoing work, the electricity junction box has been left in a vulnerable state, raising the possibility of an untoward incident. The officials concerned should ensure the safety of the public when such works are being carried out.

D.Radhakrishnan is a resident of Kilpauk



'An unauthorised dumping spot near school'



PG Avenue First Street in Kattupakkam. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

M.C.VIJAY SHANKAR

An open ground at PG Avenue First Street in Kattupakkam has become a dumping spot. Both the public and local Panchayat body are dumping waste here. Further, it is being set on fire, making it a health hazard. It may be noted the spot is in front of a school and just 100 metres from Kattupakkam metro railway station which is under construction.

M.C.Vijay Shankar is a resident of Kattupakkam

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‘Thirunindravur is poorly served by MTC bus services’

Citizens forum makes a representation to the Chief Minister seeking direct services to Tambaram and also extension of a few services up to Thirunindravur



A bus stop in Thirunindravur. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

S. MURUGAIAN

Thirunindravur Rail Passengers Welfare Association made a representation to the Chief Minister last week to improve MTC bus services that would benefit Thirunindravur commuters.

In the representation dated February 10, 2026, the Association seeks direct bus services from Thirunindravur to Tambaram and Kilambakkam operated via Nemilicherry Outer Ring Road. At present, commuters from Thirunindravur have to go to Avadi to avail services to Thirunindravur and Tambaram which is time-consuming. They also have to shell out more towards ticket fare.

The representation also highlights the need for extending the bus services of 40H (Avadi-Anna Square) and 40A (Pattabiram - Anna Square, Avadi-Anna Square) up to Thirunindravur.

Though both the services connect Anna Square their routes are different. While 40H is operated via Padi, Anna Nagar, Nelson Manickam Road and Sterling Road, 40A is operated via Thirumangalam, Anna Na-

gar, Chintamani, Shenoy Nagar, Egmore and Chepauk.

Both these services cover key government offices and a good number of colleges on their route. Hence, we want these services to be extended up to Thirunindravur. The Association also seeks the service of 24C that connects Avadi and Triplicane-Vivekananda House operated via Ambattur, Thirumangalam, Anna Nagar, Amnjikarai, Taylors Road, Chetpet, Nungambakkam Uttamar Gandhi Salai, Anna Salai - Gemini flyover and Meersapet market in Royapettah.

Earlier, commuters from Thirunindravur were largely relying on trains but now the frequency of suburban train services have reduced considerably in the last few years and commuters have no other option than relying on MTC bus services.

Since 1997, we have been taking up this issue with the elected representatives and Metropolitan Transport Corporation. But our efforts are yet to bear fruit.

S. Murugaiyan is the president of Thirunindravur Rail Passengers Welfare Association

‘Waste clogs open drain in Avadi’

D.SURESH

Redevelopment work is under way at the MTC bus terminus in Avadi on CTH Road. Operations at the terminus have been temporarily shifted to a near bylocation. However, there is a stop outside the bus terminus where buses proceeding in the direction of Thirumullaivoyal halt.

This spot is unpleasant due to the presence of an open drain, one filled with sewage-mixed stagnant water. All kinds of waste including decomposable and non-decomposable waste are dumped in the drain. The place stinks; and of course, it is a health hazard.

D.Suresh is a resident of Thirumullaivoyal



The open drain around the bus stop near Avadi terminus. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

‘Rules to curb noise pollution met with contempt in Kolathur’

DANIEL PETER

In violation of the Supreme Court’s ban on cone-shaped loud speakers, the use of the high-decibel device is widespread in Kolathur, especially at Loco Works Road in Agaram and at Jawahar Nagar. It was in use at all kinds of events held in recent months. Another violation is

the devices were blaring exceeding the permissible limits prescribed under Noise Pollution Rules - 2000. The noise is a torture, especially for the senior citizens. All these show failure on the part of the authorities concerned to enforce the rules.

Daniel Peter is a resident of Agaram

‘Print not legible in season ticket’



T. GUNASEELAN

The print of the monthly season ticket issued at the Ambattur railway station counter is of deplorable quality. The above image shows a quarterly season ticket wherein its expiry date is not clear and legible.

In case of ticket checking, who should be held responsible, the railway department or the ticket holder?

T. Gunaseelan is a resident of Ambattur

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‘Number of shelters at Korattur railway station is inadequate’

G. SINGARAVELU

Shelters at the platforms at Korattur railway station are not adequate. Better coverage is required. The number of shelters were catering to nine coaches.

The coaches have been increased to 12 in recent years, but number of shelters have not been increased. Commuters waiting under an shelter have to run and board the train when it arrives. Further, drinking water facilities need to be improved at the station.

G. Singaravelu is a resident of Korattur



Korattur railway station. PHOTO: UMESH KUMAR. V

Pavers 'retrofitted'



The plants on Anna Salai outside Government Estate Metro Station are meant to be strapping big trees. Even after a recent redemptive exercise, they continue on a restrictive space, one certainly not meant for trees



Tree pit pavers "retrofitted" in the space around young trees on the section of Anna Salai along the Government Estate Metro Station premises.

PHOTOS:
PRINCE
FREDERICK

PRINCE FREDERICK

On Anna Salai, outside the premises of the Government Estate Metro Station, plants best described as "tweens" if viewed from a human perspective, are already exposed to the vagaries of indifferent civic planning. The idea that they are an afterthought had been telegraphed to them right from their cradle.

Too old to be doted upon as saplings and too young to be dubbed trees and allowed to fend for themselves, each of them was gasping for air, the road pressing on every lobe in its "lungs". The road having closed in on them, there was no way their roots would receive any extraneous gift of water. They had to sniff their way to any moisture under the hard slab of bitumen slammed down on them. Smothered by bitumen, these plants were on a trajectory likely to end in root asphyxiation. Their growth could be stunted at best. In the worse of cases, after a tree had grown robust, it could have had a fall (a literal one) on account of its Achilles' feet. The restrictive pressure on its roots weakening it, it could become easy picking for some cyclone sometime.

Around two weeks ago, an exercise was initiated to give these trees something they should have been given at the very start of their life journeys: tree pit pavers.

Tree pit pavers have been retrofitted. That would be just a mild amelioration of a rather unhealthy environment these green beings find themselves in. They are still provided with only a narrow strip of earth untouched by civic infrastructure. And if one

took a closer look, even this patch is not as pristine as it would seem when viewed with a superficial eye. From an image or two of the work before the tree pit pavers were slipped in show a cable running alongside a tree. Besides, silt catch pits are located close to some of them.

That raises the question: was this patch the right space to grow trees? Given the general tenor of civic planning, the duple meter of rethinking and rejigging and some more rethinking and rejigging, this patch could be dug up, further unsettling the trees (that is once they have become trees). If the trees on TTK Road (particularly the rain trees, planted at a time when awareness about the necessity of promoting native species had not even put out shoots) have huge girths, they arrived before the pavements did. Urban greening now gets the species right (the ones on this section of Anna Salai are all native species) but the spaces consistently wrong. The question worth mulling over: should tree planting be allowed on sections where trees cannot be offered enough earth that is free of "development-based encumbrances".

Returning to Anna Salai, the plants might have been gifted a piece of loose soil on which pavers have been placed, but they are still pressing against the pavement. There is still suffocation, restriction of movement and lack of freedom. Managers of urban roads (in the case of Anna Salai, it would be the state highways) should pause and ponder deeply before allowing or initiating any tree planting exercise on these roads, making sure it would do justice to the trees as they grow up.

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A section of the rooftop solar installation at Bollineni Hillside off OMR.

Chennai RWA shines in TN's solar race

Bollineni Hillside has bagged an award for the biggest solar rooftop installation in Tamil Nadu in the category for resident welfare associations

PRINCE FREDERICK

Bollineni Hillside Phase I in Perumbakkam off Old Mahabalipuram Road sprawls across 45 acres and consists of 1295 dwelling units. For ease of administration, the community is cleaved in the middle, the north side servicing a half of those dwelling units and the south side the other half.

Both segments have a separate STP-WTP unit. These units are eminently useful, but are a criminal guzzler of energy, a fact that sticks out painfully when the EB bill arrives.

Sajeev Kumar, president of Bollineni Hillside Residential Township Owners Association (BHRTOA), estimates the community's monthly electricity bill at ₹10 lakh. "Electricity expense is one of the top three expenses," he points out.

The effort to whittle down that expense was launched recently, when the community had an operational solar power system in the end of January, 2026. The installation: a 97 kW solar system at one STP-WTP unit, and another 97 kW solar system at the other unit; a whopping 194 kW system in total. The decision to go solar first at these units was shaped by the consideration of significant savings on the EB bill as well as quicker recovery of the investment cost.

By virtue of going solar at this scale, BHRTOA has bagged an award from Tamil Nadu Solar Energy Developers Association (TNSEDA) for the biggest solar power installation in the RWA category across Tamil Nadu.

K. Thirugnanam, secretary, BHRTOA and an advocate, observes that the exercise synergies the various skillsets (BHRTOA president Sajeev is an IT professional) found within the community. To illustrate, he points out a retired senior official from the Tamil Nadu Electricity Board who is a resident of Bollineni Hillside was informally consulted to navigate regulatory nuances, particularly those pertaining to load thresholds and fixed charges that increase for installations exceeding 100 kW. Hence, the split into two units, each racking up 97 kW.



The question of subsidy processing

BHRTOA president Sajeev Kumar underlines the toughest part of the effort: settling on a vendor. Our vice-president Senthil Prabhu visited many RWAs that have gone solar, including those in Coimbatore.

BHRTOA treasurer Senthil Kumar S reveals that the vendor finally brought on board was found through the Federation of OMR Residents Association (FOMRRA). Senthil Kumar explains: "I had

posted a message in the FOMRRA group that we were looking for an empanelled solar rooftop installation vendor. And in the group I had also asked if anyone installed rooftop solar systems and got a subsidy for it. The overwhelming response was 'we installed, but we did not get the subsidy'. And one member in the group pointed us to this vendor who was known for diligent and effective subsidy processing."

BHRTOA secretary K. Thirug-

nanam says the selected solar energy company, Vesat Renewables Private Limited, based in Coimbatore has had a presence in the solar space for multiple decades, starting back then with solar water heaters and extending all the way to rooftop solar installations now. Contrary to the views held by many other vendors that had been approached earlier, this one was aware that RWAs were eligible for subsidy under PM's Surya Ghar Scheme. And BHRTOA was convinced of the company's end-to-end execution capability, particularly subsidy processing.

In sheer numbers

Estimating the cost of things under the sun is Senthil Kumar S's bailiwick as he is a chartered accountant. And he is particularly interested in working out the cost analysis of the solar endeavour at BHRTOA Phase I as he is its treasurer.

Here is what this exercise means to the community, in sheer numbers, as propounded by Senthil.

Installed capacity: 194 kW
Gross project cost: ₹1.1-1.2 crore

Subsidy received under centre's PM Surya Ghar scheme: **₹35 lakh**

Net investment: ₹85 lakh

Estimated annual savings: **₹25 lakh**

Expected payback: **3.5 to 4 years**

Assumed panel life: **25 years**

Estimated 25-year savings: **₹7**

plus crore

Senthil proceeds to do an ROI analysis:

*If ₹1 crore were placed in a fixed deposit (at approximately 7.5% annual return), the amount to flow in would be ₹7.5 lakh, which would be taxable.

*In contrast, the solar investment promises ₹25 lakh annual savings at a 25% return; and these are non-taxed operational savings.



From the awards ceremony.

Young talent in music, dance honoured

Shri Vallabh Cultural Academy hosted the second edition of Vallabh Yuva Kala Awards

Six persons were honoured with Vallabh Yuva Kala Awards for their excellence in the fields of classical music and dance. The winners were honoured with a citation and a cash prize.

They are: Nivedha Harish, Grade-B Bharatanatyam artiste of Doordarshan Kendra and recipient of the 'Young artiste scholarship' from the Ministry of Culture; and Nanditha Kannan, an All India Radio B-Grade Carnatic Vocal artiste and recipient of 'IWA National



From the event.

Award' and 'Nada Pallava Award' M.K. Ananthabalasubramaniam, recognised as an 'Upcoming

Artist' at the Vipanchee Art Festival; K. Gowtham Balaji, who has worked in music production and

audio engineering for Tamil and Telugu cinema industries; N. Veda Janani, Kuchipudi dancer and reci-

pient of 'Shrestha Kala Yashaswi Award'; and Yogithaa R., Bharatanatyam dancer recognised with the 'Nrithya Vichithra Award' were presented a citation and a cash award of Rs. 50,000.

Shri Vallabh Cultural Academy is an initiative of Shri Vallabhacharya Vidya Sabha. The cultural organisation aims to promote Indian culture and tradition by creating opportunities for the intensive pursuit of Indian art forms.

V.V. Sabha was established in 1963 in Madras with the mission of imparting quality education. Under the auspices of the Sabha, two colleges - D.G. Vaishnav College in 1964, and M.O.P. Vaishnav College for Women in 1992 and two schools, Kola Perumal Chetty Vaishnav Senior Secondary School in 1972, and Kola Saraswati Vaishnav Senior Secondary School in 1975 were established. Besides, the Sabha also supports the M.O.P. Vaishnav High school and Vaishnav Sports Academy.

MCC Chetpet wins chess tourney

Good response to 10th Dr. Gift Siromoney Memorial Inter-School Chess Tournament and Sports Quiz held at Madras Christian College



Demonstrating strategy, analytical thinking and sporting spirit, the Department of Statistics at Madras Christian College (MCC) organised the 10th Dr. Gift Siromoney Memorial Inter-School Chess Tournament and Sports Quiz on its campus recently.

Marking a decade of nurturing young talent, the tournament was conducted with the support of Emmanuel Chess Centre and the 1984-87 Statistics Graduate Class. The

event brought together enthusiastic participation from 13 schools, with a total of 70 students competing in both intellectual and sporting contests, said a press release.

The programme was inaugurated by the chief guests Ebenezer Joseph and N. Soorya Prakash, who encouraged students to approach the competitions with confidence, discipline and true sportsmanship. Ebenezer Joseph, an alumnus of the department (1984-89 batch), is a Candidate Master and

India's FIDE Trainer, currently serving as Supervisor (Audit) in the Indian Audit and Accounts Department. He also conducted the chess tournament.

The Sports Quiz was conducted by N. Soorya Prakash, an alumnus of the department (1986-1991 batch) and Assistant General Manager, Sales & Distribution Department, *The Hindu*. He engaged the participants with questions based on major sporting events and achievements of 2025.

Adding an academic dimension to the event, students of the department organised a Statistics Exhibition showcasing over 30 innovative statistical models. These exhibits illustrated practical applications of statistical concepts and drew keen interest from visiting school students and teachers alike, said the release.

The prestigious Dr. Gift Siromoney, Wesley Stephen, and Rev. Anand Jayakumar Rolling Trophies were awarded to the top three schools overall. The Dr. J. P. Vijaya Thilakan Rolling Trophy was presented to the best-performing Government school, recognising excellence and encouraging broader participation.

In the chess tournament, MCC Higher Secondary School, Chetpet, emerged as the overall winner, with MCC Campus School, East Tambaram, securing second place. In the Government school category, MPS Government School earned top honours. In the Sports Quiz competition, Gateway - The Complete School, Sholinganallur, claimed first place, followed by MCC Campus Matriculation Higher Secondary School, added the release.

In the Government school category, MPS Government School earned top honours

Seventy students took part in the event.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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School launches organ donation awareness club

Students of The Pupil International School, in collaboration with MOHAN Foundation, take up an awareness campaign

On February 3, The Pupil International School conducted GOAL - Gift Of A Life, an organ donation awareness campaign led by MYP Year 3 students as a 'Service as Action' initiative in collaboration with MOHAN Foundation. Students anchored the programme through a thoughtfully planned sequence that included a skit, song, and a student-made short film, followed by a pledge

that reinforced responsible citizenship, said a release.

The guest of honour, Dr. Sunil Shroff, Founder and Managing Trustee of the MOHAN Foundation, addressed the students and attendees and inaugurated the school's Organ Donation Awareness Club to ensure sustained, student-led advocacy beyond the event. The session also included a moving address by Mr. Hariharan, who shared his life journey as a kidney transplant recipient, bringing the message of organ donation to life with authenticity and hope. The programme concluded with the recognition of students who completed Angels of Change, MOHAN Foundation's awareness and advocacy certification course that equips learners with accurate information, ethical understanding, and communication skills to promote organ donation awareness, through the distribution of certificates.



Culinary workshop

Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre is conducting a workshop on ready-to-cook food items on February 19. According to a press release, the items include: rava idli mix, adai, vadai, and payasam. The session will also focus on making flavour powders meant for Indian non-vegetarian gravies.

Another session on making soaps will be conducted on February 20. There will be demonstrations on making soaps from herbs, flowers, and sandal oil.

Both the sessions will be held at the centre's premises at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Guindy.

For details, call : 044 - 29530048.

Workshop on making ice-creams from millets

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, a Department of MSME - Tamil Nadu, is organizing a training programme on making ice



creams from wheat and millets. It will be held from February 19 to 20. Time: From 10 a.m. to 5 p.m. at the centre's premises at No: 1, EDII Road, SIDCO Industrial Estate, Ekkaduthangal, Guindy. For details, call 8668102600 / 8754495254.

Workshop on crochet

A workshop on crochet will be conducted for beginners on February 18 at Navin's Hanging Gardens, Valasaravakkam. Time: From 10.30 a.m. to 1 p.m. According to a press release, no fee will be charged. The basics of the crafts such chain stitch, single crochet, double crochet, triple crochet and a few more will be demonstrated. The session will be conducted by Rajani Kumari. For details, call 99403 12650.

Training session on gold appraisal

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute is organising a workshop on gold appraisal from February 16 to 20 at its premises at No: 1, EDII Road, SIDCO Industrial Estate, Ekkaduthangal, Guindy. Time From 10 a.m. to 5 p.m.

According to a press release, the session covers the following: concepts in metallurgy with focus on gold and silver, difference between karat and carat, methods for calculating gold purity, and jewel loan assessment procedures. The programme aims to prepare the participants to set up an enterprise in gem and jewellery sector. Further, they will find part-time job opportunities in banks as gold assayer, adds the press release. For details, call 9360221280 / 8668100181.

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CLASSIC NORTH INDIAN DINING IN ANNA NAGAR

In a city celebrated for its local cuisine, the quiet persistence of a North Indian kitchen that refuses to compromise can feel almost radical. Tucked away in Anna Nagar, away from the predictable spotlight of high-street dining, The New Punjab Club has steadily built a reputation as one of the city's most compelling North Indian restaurants.



The New Punjab Club has resisted the urge to dilute its identity, and has carved out a distinct space - one that appeals to culinary connoisseurs, non-vegetarian enthusiasts and families alike.

For those willing to look beyond the obvious, Anna Nagar's hidden gem offers a reminder that great food does not always need reinvention - sometimes, it just needs to be done right.

In an era where "North Indian" has often been reduced to a shorthand of butter-laden gravies and generic masalas, this restaurant promises to serve food that stays true to its roots. Gravies are built patiently, with layers of flavour developed through slow cooking rather than shortcuts. The richness is measured, not excessive.

